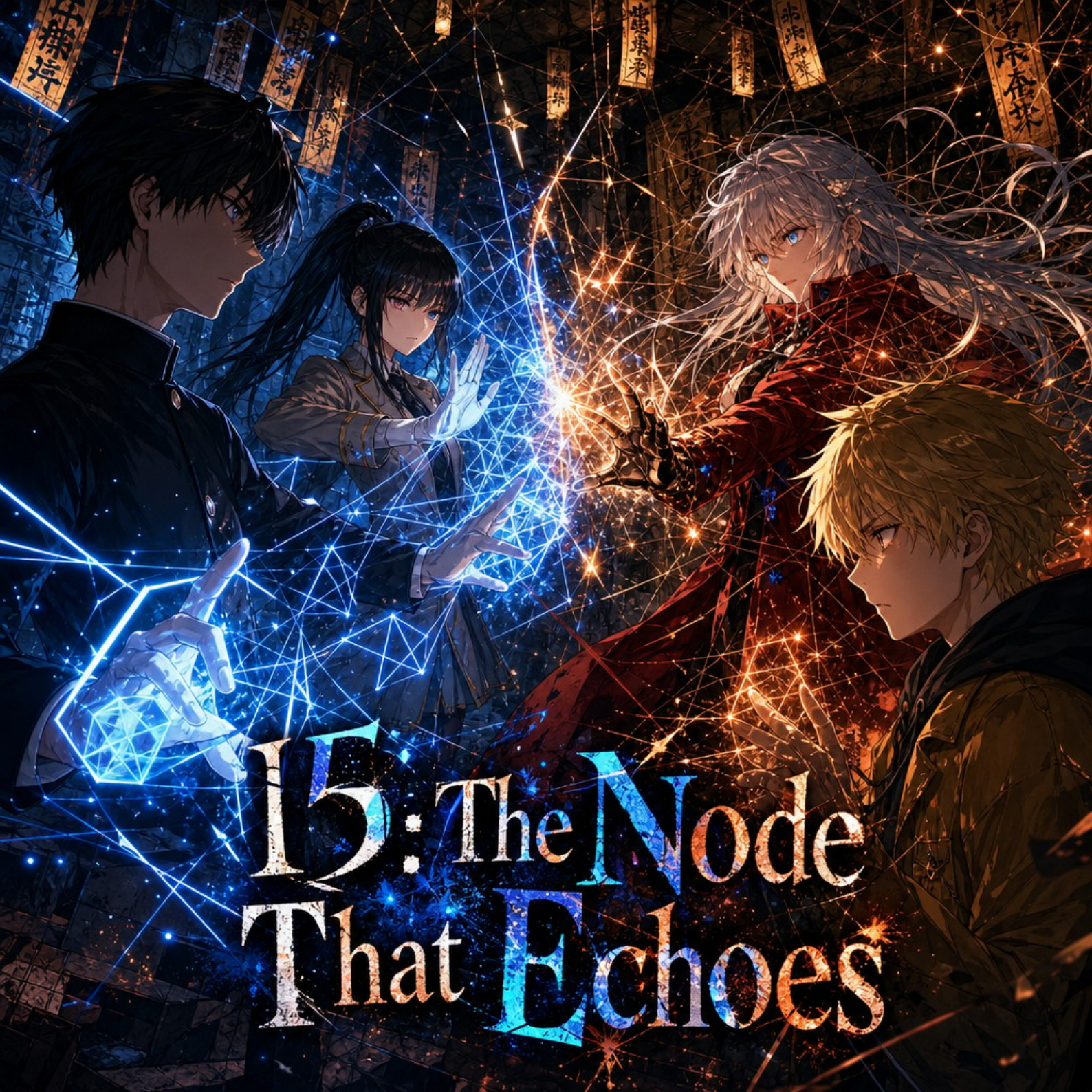




15: The Node That Echoes



THE REAR
GARDEN.

THE STOREHOUSE
(KURA).

BEYOND THE
MAIN HOUSE.

BEYOND
SPEECH.



SORA MINABE.
16.
READER OF
THE FUTURE.

THE INVISIBLE
BOY.



ASTRID BRANDT.
17.
READER OF
THE WEB.

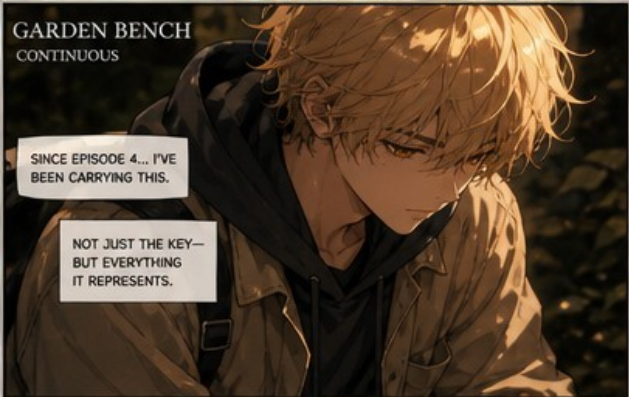
THE GIRL WHO
SEES THROUGH
EVERYTHING.



TWO READERS.
ONE THRESHOLD.

KNOWING.

REVELATION.



SINCE EPISODE 4... I'VE
BEEN CARRYING THIS.

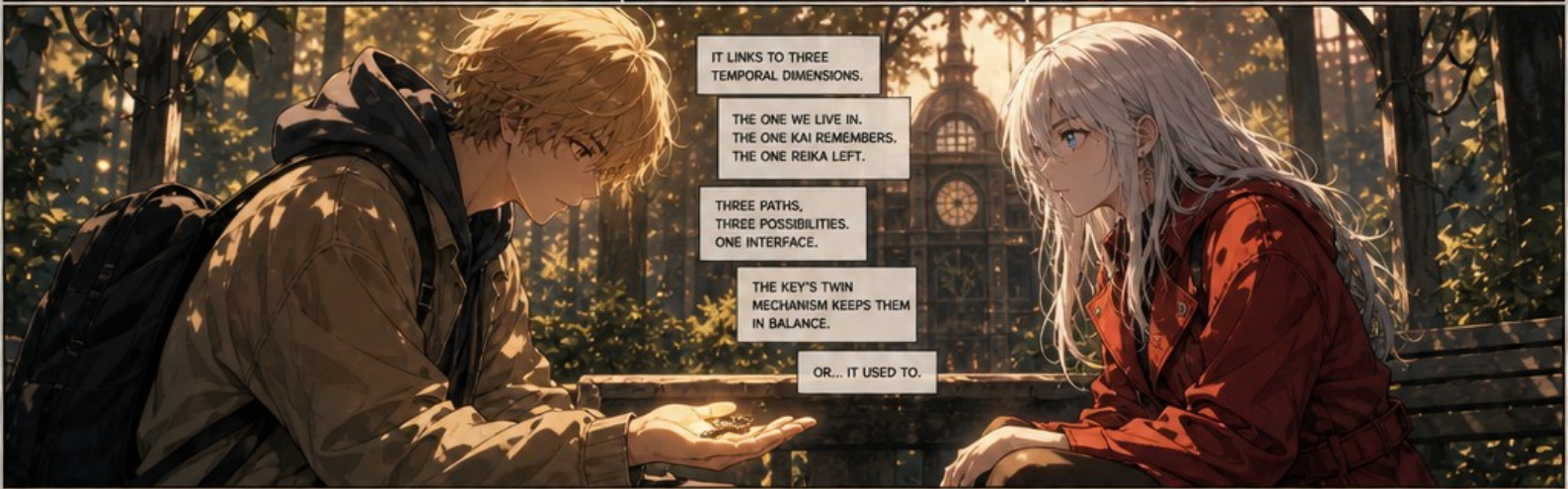
NOT JUST THE KEY—
BUT EVERYTHING
IT REPRESENTS.



THIS IS THE HEIRLOOM
KEY...
THE OPEN END.
ITS TWIN IS PART OF
SOMETHING MUCH
LARGER.



BENEATH MY SCHOOL,
THERE'S A BASEMENT
NODE. AN INTERFACE.
BUILT BY MY
GRANDFATHER.



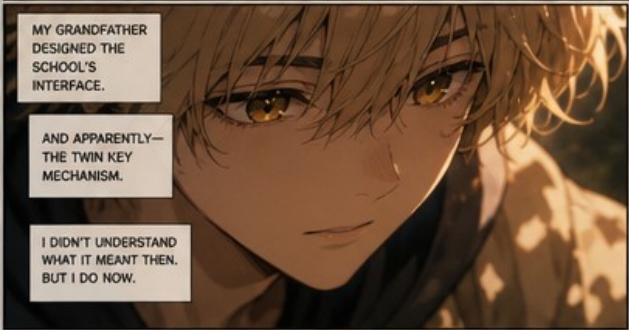
IT LINKS TO THREE
TEMPORAL DIMENSIONS.

THE ONE WE LIVE IN.
THE ONE KAI REMEMBERS.
THE ONE REIKA LEFT.

THREE PATHS.
THREE POSSIBILITIES.
ONE INTERFACE.

THE KEY'S TWIN
MECHANISM KEEPS THEM
IN BALANCE.

OR... IT USED TO.



MY GRANDFATHER
DESIGNED THE
SCHOOL'S
INTERFACE.

AND APPARENTLY—
THE TWIN KEY
MECHANISM.

I DIDN'T UNDERSTAND
WHAT IT MEANT THEN.
BUT I DO NOW.



MY CONSEQUENCE-DREAD...
IT DOESN'T JUST POINT
AT THINGS.

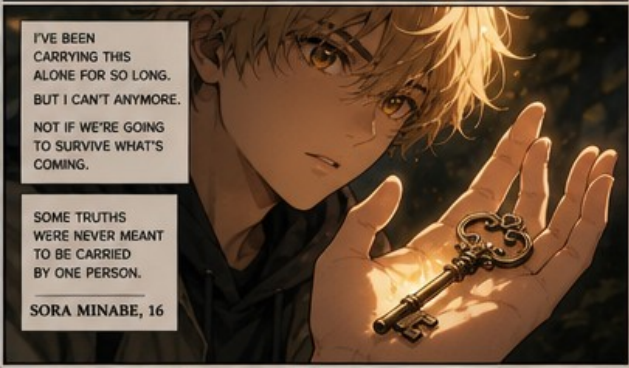
IT SHOWS ME
CONNECTIONS.

WHEN IT POINTS AT
TWO THINGS TOGETHER—
THEY BELONG TOGETHER.

RIGHT NOW...
IT'S POINTING AT
THE STOREHOUSE.
AND AT YOU.
AT THE SAME TIME.

SHE DOESN'T INTERRUPT.
SHE DOESN'T FLIPPED HER
BINDER.
SHE JUST LISTENS.

FULL ATTENTION.
NO DEFENSE.
NO DISTRACTIONS.
JUST... RECEPTION.



I'VE BEEN
CARRYING THIS
ALONE FOR SO LONG.
BUT I CAN'T ANYMORE.
NOT IF WE'RE GOING
TO SURVIVE WHAT'S
COMING.

SOME TRUTHS
WERE NEVER MEANT
TO BE CARRIED
BY ONE PERSON.

SORA MINABE, 16

I'M TELLING YOU NOW,
BECAUSE WHATEVER
HAPPENS NEXT—
YOU NEED THE FULL MAP.

NOT JUST THE PIECES
I COULD BEAR.

THIS IS MY BURDEN.
NOW IT'S ALSO OURS.



SHE LOOKS AT THE
STOREHOUSE AGAIN.
NOT WITH CURIOSITY.
NOT WITH DOUBT.
WITH CALCULATION.

SUDDENLY,
IT'S OBVIOUS.
OF COURSE.
IT ALL CONNECTS.
EVERYTHING
CONNECTS.

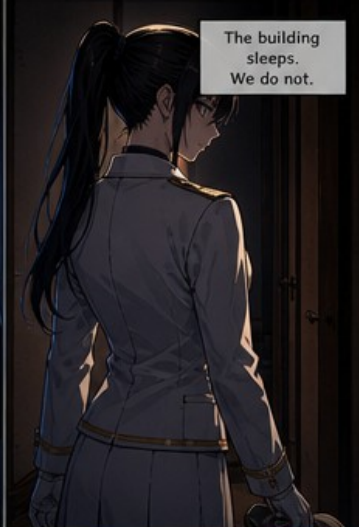
ASTRID BRANDT, 17



Now.
Before
sunrise.



Four readers.
Four burdens.
One timing.



The building
sleeps.
We do not.



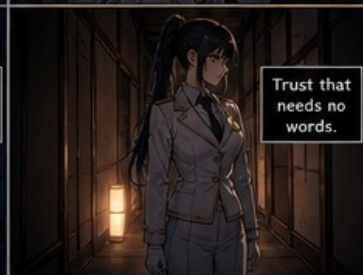
Slippers
over
silence.



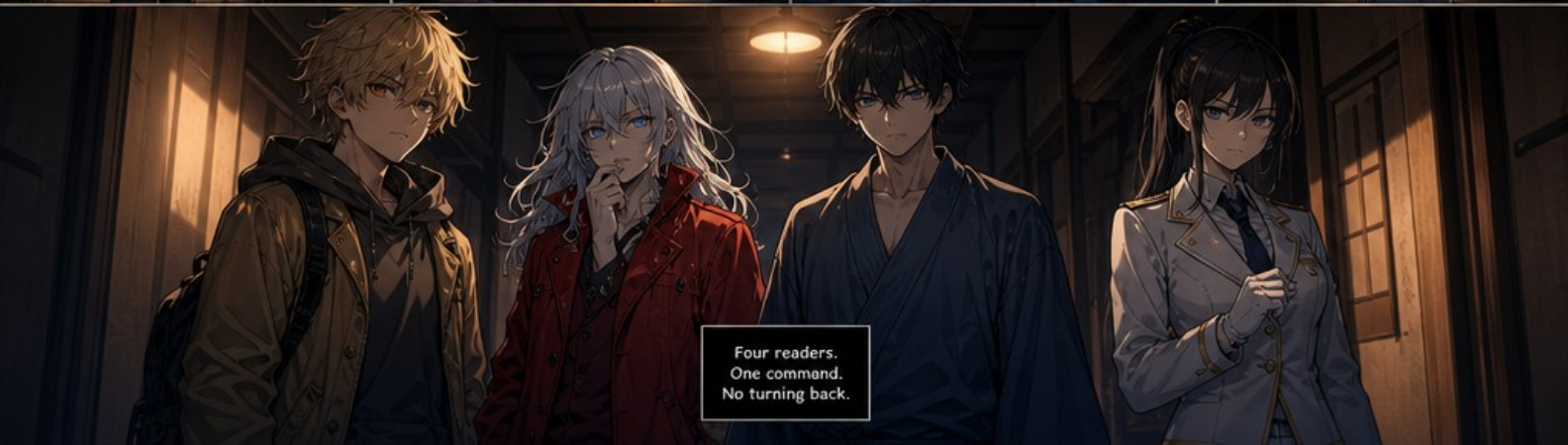
Doors that
should stay
closed.



Steps that
shouldn't
exist.



Trust that
needs no
words.



Four readers.
One command.
No turning back.

1.

THE KEY
APPROACHES
THE KEYHOLE.

SORA MINABE

16

THE READER OF THE FUTURE

2.

CONTACT.
A FAINT
WARMTH
VISIBLE AT
THE KEY'S
EDGE.

3.

THE LOCK
TURNS WITH
UNEXPECTED
EASE.

THE MECHANISM
RESPONDS—
THE SAME
TÔMEI KIKAN
STANDARD
INTERFACE.

NOT HIS
GRANDFATHER'S
EXACT KEY,
BUT THE SAME
TÔMEI KIKAN
STANDARD
INTERFACE,
BUILT FOR
NETWORK-WIDE
COMPATIBILITY.

4.

THE TRAPDOOR
LIFTS.

A SLOW EXHALE
OF COLD,
OLD AIR—
AND, FAINTLY,
A PALE
GEOMETRIC
LIGHT FROM
BELOW.

COLDER.
BLUER.
OLDER.

DIFFERENT IN
QUALITY FROM
THE SCHOOL
NODE'S WARM
FIELD-GLOW.



THIS ISN'T
THE SCHOOL'S
FIELD-INTERFACE.



THE HISTORY
HERE IS...
DENSER.

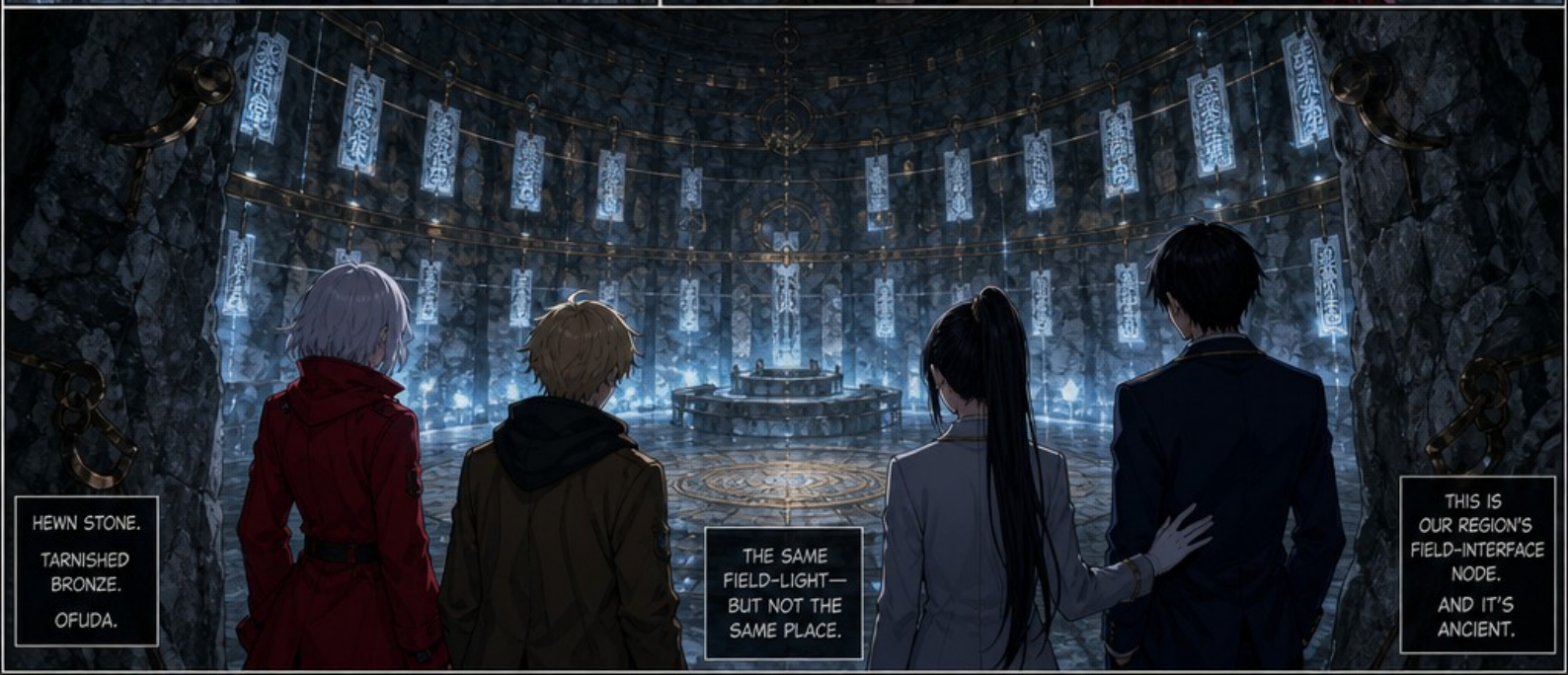
OLDER
THAN THE
TEMPLE.



IT FEELS...
ALIVE.



ANOTHER
NODE.
ANOTHER
RULE SET.



HEWN STONE.
TARNISHED
BRONZE.
OFUDA.

THE SAME
FIELD-LIGHT—
BUT NOT THE
SAME PLACE.

THIS IS
OUR REGION'S
FIELD-INTERFACE
NODE.
AND IT'S
ANCIENT.



NOT AN INTERFACE.
AN OBSERVATION STATION.
BUILT TO RECORD AND SUPPRESS.



UNFAMILIAR NOTATION.
DIFFERENT MATHEMATICAL
CONVENTION.



EVIDENCE OF A SEPARATE
ARCHITECT'S DESIGN PHILOSOPHY.



REGIONAL
DIALECT.

SAME PURPOSE.
DIFFERENT HAND.

A SUPPRESSION-RECORDING
METHOD PASSED DOWN...
PARTIALLY PRESERVED IN
THE TENDO FAMILY BINDER.



BRITTLE OFUDA
TALISMANS.

AGED. FRAGILE.
NOT BRASS.



DIFFERENT REGIONS.
DIFFERENT METHODS.
SAME SILENCING SYSTEM.

THE REGIONAL
NODE CHAMBER.

CONTINUOUS.

SORA MINABE, 16,
THE READER OF THE FUTRE,
WARM AMBER PALETTE.
SMALL AND UNREMARKABLE,
MOVES TO THE CENTRE OF
THE BRONZE CALIBRATION
RING WITHOUT BEING TOLD TO,—

THE WAY HE INSTINCTIVELY
FOUND THE CENTRE OF THE
SCHOOL'S NODE IN EPISODE 12,—

—AND FEELS THE CHAMBER'S
FIELD-PRESSURE SETTLE
AROUND HIM WITH THE SPECIFIC
ALIGNMENT-WITHOUT-FRICTION
QUALITY HIS GIFT HAS ONLY
OTHERWISE FOUND IN HIS
OWN SCHOOL'S NODE.

THE QUIET
RECOGNITION
OF A SPACE
BUILT, HOWEVER
LONG AGO AND
BY HOWEVER
DIFFERENT
A HAND, FOR
EXACTLY THIS
KIND OF
STANDING-IN-
THE-CENTRE.

REIKA TENDO
TAKES A
POSITION NEAR
THE STONE WALL
HUNG WITH OFUDA,
HER BARE HAND
FINALLY MAKING
CONTACT WITH
ONE TALISMAN'S
EDGE,—

A BRIEF
DESATURATED
PAST-FLASH
FLICKERING AT
THE PANEL'S
CORNER.

ASTRID BRANDT
STANDS NEAR
THE CHAMBER'S
THRESHOLD,
HER GRANDFATHER'S
RING-BINDER
OPEN AGAIN,
CROSS-REFERENCING
SOMETHING IN ITS
PAGES AGAINST
THE BRONZE RING'S
ENGRAVED NOTATION
WITH VISIBLE
EXCITEMENT—

—THE FIRST
UNGUARDED
ENTHUSIASM
THE AUDIENCE
HAS SEEN
FROM HER.

THE THREE READERS
OCCUPY ASYMMETRIC
SPATIAL POSITIONS—

CENTRE, WALL,
THRESHOLD—

CREATING VISUAL
TENSION AND NARRATIVE
SYNCHRONIZATION.

REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER

CONTINUOUS REIKA TENDO
THE READER OF THE PAST

REIKA TENDO, 18
THE READER OF THE PAST

BARE HAND NOW
FLAT AGAINST
A CLUSTER OF
THE OLDEST OFUDA
TALISMANS...

RECEIVING
THE CHAMBER'S
ACCUMULATED
RECORDS IN FULL.

(A PAST-VISION FLOODS
THE PANEL—DESATURATED.)

ROBED FIGURES IN AN ERA
PREDATING THE SCHOOL'S
TÔMEI KIKAN GENERATION
BY DECADES...

WORKING IN THIS SAME
STONE CHAMBER...

RECORDING FIELD-PRESSURE
READINGS ONTO PAPER
TALISMANS, WITH THE
PATIENT, METHODICAL
CARE OF AN ENTIRELY
DIFFERENT SCIENTIFIC
TRADITION.

FRAGMENTS
OF WHAT THEY
RECORDED—

INCOMPLETE
REGIONAL
DOCUMENTATION.

REFERENCES
TO OTHER NODES.

A NETWORK
SKETCHED FAINTLY
IN THE VISION'S
BACKGROUND—

LIKE A HALF-
REMEMBERED MAP.

THE SCOPE
STRETCHES FAR
BEYOND ANY ONE
INSTITUTION.

THERE
WERE MORE.

THIS WAS
NEVER JUST US.

REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER
CONTINUOUS REGISTER

KAI MORI, 17.
THE READER OF TRUTH.

STANDS AT THE
BRONZE CALIBRATION
RING.

READS THE
PRESENT-TRUTH
OF THIS CHAMBER.



SUBJECTIVE-POV:
HIS COLD-BLUE GEOMETRIC GRID
FILLS THE SMALL STONE ROOM.

DORMANT PRESSURE VISIBLE
AS COMPRESSED, TIGHTLY COILED
ENERGY.

NOT THE SCHOOL NODE'S
PATIENT WARMTH. SOMETHING
DENSER, OLDER.
HELD UNDER GREATER
COMPRESSION.
FOR A LONGER SILENCE.



PRESENT-FACT:
THIS NODE HAS BEEN
REGISTERING THE REGION'S
SUPPRESSION-PRESSURE
CONTINUOUSLY.

UNATTENDED.
FOR THE ENTIRE SPAN OF
ITS DORMANCY.

AN INSTRUMENT LEFT RUNNING.
NO ONE TO READ ITS OUTPUT.
FOR GENERATIONS.
DECADES. CENTURIES.



HIS FACE:
THE COLD RECOGNITION OF
AN ENORMOUS QUANTITY
OF UNREAD DATA.
A LIBRARY NO ONE
CAME BACK TO.

THE CHAMBER BREATHES
WITH COMPRESSED,
COILED DORMANT ENERGY.
DENSE GEOMETRIC LATTICES
OF COLD BLUE LIGHT.
LAYERED. TIGHTENING.
OLDER THAN ANYTHING
HE HAS ENCOUNTERED.
BEFORE.



HIS RECOGNITION
OF THIS ISOLATION—
A MACHINE LEFT RUNNING
FOR GENERATIONS,
NO ONE TO WITNESS
ITS TRUTH—

MANIFESTS AS THE
SINGULAR EMOTIONAL
ANCHOR.

HIS COLD INTENSITY
THE ONLY HUMAN
COUNTERPOINT TO THE
CHAMBER'S INHUMAN
COMPRESSION
AND WEIGHT.

THE WEIGHT
OF UNREAD
CENTURIES
PRESSES
AGAINST HIS
CONSCIOUSNESS.

THE GROWING FEAR
THAT HE IS LOSING
HIS MIND.



REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER,
CONTINUOUS

THE CONSEQUENCE
OF THE CHAMBER'S CONTENTS
IF SURFACED—NOT AIMED AT
ANY SINGLE EVENT, BUT AT
THE REGION ITSELF.

THE SHAPE OF WHAT THE
TEMPLE'S ERASED HISTORY
AND THIS NODE'S
ACCUMULATED RECORDS
WOULD CHANGE IN THE
AREA'S SELF-UNDERSTANDING
IF COMBINED AND RELEASED.



SORA MINABE, 16
THE READER OF THE FUTURE



IT WOULD
CHANGE WHAT
THIS WHOLE REGION
THINKS IT IS.

HE DOES NOT SAY
WHETHER THAT CHANGE
WOULD BE GOOD.

HE HAS LEARNED, SINCE
THE TEMPLE, THAT THE
QUESTION DOES NOT
RESOLVE CLEANLY—

EVEN WHEN FELT
WITH TOTAL CLARITY.

THE CHAMBER'S OWN FIELD-PRESSURE
IS AMPLIFYING AND STEADYING HIS GIFT—
THE WAY IT STEADIES KAI'S AND REIKA'S.

EPISODE 13:
DIRECTIONLESS DREAD.



NOW: AMPLIFIED CLARITY
WITHIN THE NODE'S FIELD.



A TEENAGE BOY
HOLDING THE FUTURE
OF AN ENTIRE REGION'S
SELF-UNDERSTANDING.

HISTORICAL ERASURE.



ACCUMULATED RECORDS.



COMBINED. RELEASED.



HIS QUIET GRAVITY ANCHORS THE ENTIRE CHAMBER'S FIELD-PRESSURE.
HIS MINIMAL STATEMENT CARRIES THE FULL WEIGHT OF HISTORICAL ERASURE AND ACCUMULATED TRUTH.

THE FOUR-WAY COMBINATION
FIRST ATTEMPT

KAI'S CALCULATION.
REIKA'S HISTORY.
SORA'S CONSEQUENCE.

THREE SYSTEMS.
ONE CIRCUIT.

ASTRID'S SIGHT.
DIFFERENT ANGLE.
SAME SPACE.

WRONG FREQUENCY.
FRICTION.

SUBJECTIVE: ASTRID

KAI: STRUCTURE

REIKA: PAST

MY THREADS
DON'T MERGE.
THEY STRIKE.
NOT BROKEN—
JUST WRONG.

ASTRID: SIGHT

SORA: CONSEQUENCE

TWO SYSTEMS.
BUILT APART.
REFUSING
TO SHARE.
NOT YET.

KAI MORI
ANALYTICAL
OBSERVATION

THE ANGLE...
IT SHOULDN'T—
THAT'S NOT
HOW THIS
CIRCUIT—

REIKA TENDO
HISTORICAL
PROCESSING

NO—
THAT ERA—
THAT'S NOT
CONNECTED—
WHY IS IT—

SORA MINABE
CONSEQUENCE
READING

THE RIPPLES—
THEY'RE
CONFLICTING—
PEOPLE COULD
GET HURT—

FIRST ATTEMPT.
OF COURSE IT
DIDN'T SYNC.
I DIDN'T BUILD
THIS SYSTEM.

BUT I WILL
MAKE IT WORK.
EVEN IF THE
FIRST CONTACT
SPARKS.

REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER.

THE CHAMBER'S
PALE NODE-LIGHT
FLICKERS WITH
JARRING INTENSITY.

THE FRICTION BETWEEN
ASTRID'S WEB AND THE
TRIAD'S CIRCUIT WIDENS
INTO SOMETHING
COLDER.

VELETH CUT.

ANGLE SHIFT:
DISORIENTING.
SHARP.

TEMPERATURE
DROPPING
SHARPLY
THROUGH
THE SPACE.

KAI MORI.

MID-COMBINATION.

HE FEELS NOT
REIKA'S AND SORA'S
FAMILIAR PRESENCE
BESIDE HIM—

BUT ASTRID'S
UNFAMILIAR AMBER-
BROWN THREADS AS
INTRUSION.

A TECHNICAL
INCOMPATIBILITY
SEIZED AND
SHARPENED INTO
FALSE PERCEPTION—

THAT ASTRID
HERSELF IS THE
DISRUPTION RATHER
THAN HER GIFT'S
ORTHOGONAL
GEOMETRY.

HIS COLD DETACHMENT
MASK TIGHTENS.
TENSION VISIBLE ONLY
IN THE RIGID OBSESSIVE
CALCULATION BURNING
THROUGH HIS GAZE.

REIKA TENDO.

EIGHTEEN.

LONG SLEEK BLACK
HAIR IN A HIGH,
DISCIPLINED PONYTAIL
FLOWING BEHIND HER.

SHE STANDS WITH
RIGIDLY UPRIGHT
PERFECTLY
SYMMETRICAL
POSTURE.

HER DARK,
DIRECT,
UNFLINCHING
EYES FRAMED
BY HER LIGHT
GREY BLAZER
WITH GOLD
TRIM, DARK
TIE, DARK
PLEATED
SKIRT.

IMMACULATE
WHITE GLOVES
REFUSING TO
TOUCH HER
ENVIRONMENT.

HER PAST-VISION—
ALREADY DESTABILIZED—
BRIEFLY SHOWS HER FEAR
ABOUT WHAT TRUSTING
A FOURTH PERCEIVER
MIGHT COST THE BOND
SHE HAS ONLY JUST
LEARNED TO KEEP.

HER COMPOSED NO-
NONSENSE EXPRESSION
MASKING OVERWHELMING
BURDEN.

ASTRID BRANDT.

STRIKING AND
INTENSE.

LONG TOUSLED
SILVERY-WHITE
HAIR FRAMING
WIDE, PIERCING
BRIGHT BLUE
EYES.

HER SIGNATURE
VIBBANT RED
TRENCH COAT
SLIGHTLY
TATTERED AND
WORN, DARK
HIGH-COLLARED
GARMENT
BENEATH.

HER NATURAL
BODY LANGUAGE
CARRYING
LINGERING HAND
GESTURES OF
A SMOKER.

UPRIGHT
UNBOtherED
POSTURE
MAINTAINING
COOL, IRONIC
COMPOSURE AND
FEARLESS SELF-
POSSESSION.

THE FOUR HOLD THEIR POSITIONS.
STRAINING AGAINST THE COLD STUTTER
AND FALSE INTRUSION.

THE MOMENT STRETCHES.
GEOMETRIC AND FRACTURED.

TECHNICAL FRICTION RENDERED AS
PSYCHOLOGICAL RUPTURE THROUGH
PERCEPTION RATHER THAN EXTERNAL
MANIFESTATION.

THE REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER. CONTINUOUS.

ASTRID BRANDT
17.

Gift: Thread-Sight.
Reads connections
and trajectories.
Not things.
Never has.

LOOKING
DIRECTLY IS
OVERRATED.

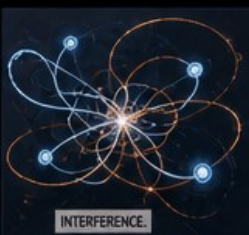
I'LL READ
WHAT LEAVES.

THE TRIAD'S SIGHT:
CLEAN, PRECISE,
LOCAL.

ASTRID'S ANGLE:
OBLIQUE, EXTERNAL,
RELATIONAL.

LET'S SEE
WHAT THIS
THING TOUCHES.

THE COMBINATION: SPARK. STUTTER. RESOLVE.



KZZT--



--KZZT--



--KLIK.

NOT A MERGE.
TWO SYSTEMS.
ONE ORIENTATION.

THE TRIAD HOLDS
THE POINT.

ASTRID MAPS
THE EDGES.

TOGETHER, WE DON'T JUST SEE THIS CHAMBER.

WE SEE THE PATTERN.

OTHER NODES.

OTHER REGIONS.

BERLIN.

SAME HAND.

THE THREAD DOESN'T STOP AT THE SEA.
IT NEVER DID.

NATIONAL
BOUNDARIES?

CUTE.

THESE PEOPLE
DON'T JUST
COLLABORATE--

THEY
ARCHITECT.

BERLIN WASN'T
A ROGUE NODE.

IT WAS
THE MEETING
POINT.

ASTRID BRANDT.
TELLS THE TRUTH
WITHOUT ASKING
PERMISSION.

INSTITUTIONS FAIL.
NETWORKS ENDURE.

AND SOMEONE HAS
TO CALL IT WHAT IT IS.

COMPLICITY.

REGIONAL NODE CHAMBER
CONTINUOUS

ES GEHT
NACH BERLIN.
ES GIBT ETWAS
IN BERLIN, DAS
MIT DEM HIER
VERBUNDEN IST.
MEIN GROSS-
VATER WUSSTE
DAVON.

それはベルリンに
繋がっている。
ベルリンにはここに
繋がる何かがある。
祖父はそれを
知っていた。

ASTRID BRANDT, 17
THE READER OF THE WEB

REIKA TENDO
S1 SURVIVOR
HEAD DISCIPLINARIAN

THE CABINET'S
GERMAN DRAWER
MECHANISM.
HER GRANDFATHER'S
INHERITANCE.



BERLIN...?
AND HERE...?
THE SAME
NETWORK...?

THE BRONZE
CALIBRATION RING'S
ANCIENT INSTRUMENTS
RESPOND: A FAINT
RESONANT HUM.

THE ENGRAVED
NOTATION BRIEFLY
GLOWING BRIGHTER.



RECOGNITION
PASSING BETWEEN
TWO OBJECTS
BUILT A CONTINENT
APART FOR THE
SAME NETWORK.

ES GEHT NACH
BERLIN. ES GIBT
ETWAS IN BERLIN,
DAS MIT DEM HIER
VERBUNDEN IST.
MEIN GROSSVATER
WUSSTE DAVON.

それはベルリンに
繋がっている。
ベルリンにはここに
繋がる何かがある。
祖父はそれを
知っていた。

SO IT'S
TRUE...

THE S1 FINALE
WASN'T THE END
OF THE STORY...

GLOBAL
REACH.
INHERITED
COMPLICITY.



EPISODE 15: THE COMBINATION RELEASING

THE REGIONAL
NODE CHAMBER.

THE COMBINATION
RELEASING.

ALL FOUR
BREATHING HARD.

THE PALE FIELD-LIGHT
SETTLING BACK TO
ITS DORMANT LOW GLOW.

CLACK

SORA MINABE
LOCKS THE TRAPDOOR'S
MECHANISM ABOVE THEM
AS THEY CLIMB BACK UP
THE STONE STAIRWAY
INTO THE STOREHOUSE.

HIS POSTURE
PROTECTIVE AND
BURDENED BY
INVISIBLE WEIGHT AS
HE SEALS THE CHAMBER
BELOW.

REIKA TENDO, 18,
EMERGES INTO THE
STOREHOUSE'S DIM
MOONLIT INTERIOR.

HER POSTURE RIGIDLY
UPRIGHT AND ASSERTIVE,
HER EYES DIRECT
AND UNFLINCHING
THOUGH MARKED BY
PROFOUND EXHAUSTION.

YOUR
GRANDFATHER
BUILT SOMETHING
TOO.

ASTRID BRANDT, 17,
HER SIGNATURE RED
TRENCH COAT TATTERED
AND WORN, HER POISE
CARRYING LINGERING
HAND GESTURES WITH
COOL, IRONIC COMPOSURE
AND FEARLESS
SELF-POSSESSION.

YES.

BUT HE WAS
ALSO THE
OTHER THING.

EVERYTHING
MY GRANDFATHER
COULD ENCODE
BEFORE THE
WALL FELL.

COME AND SEE.

REIKA UNDERSTANDS
WITHOUT NEEDING
EXPLANATION FURTHER.

KAI MORI, 17,
STANDS IN IMMACULATE
GEOMETRIC PRECISION.

HIS HANDS DEEP
IN HIS POCKETS,
HIS COLD, DETACHED
MASK FIXED AS HE
LOOKS DIRECTLY AT
ASTRID—

WHAT DO YOU
KNOW ABOUT
THE CABINET?

A TRIP THAT WAS
SUPPOSED TO BE A BREAK
OPENING THE NEXT STAGE
OF THE WAR.

FOUR OF THEM
NOW INSTEAD OF THREE.

THE STOREHOUSE DOORWAY
AT FIRST LIGHT MARKS
THE SEASON'S THRESHOLD
INTO THE WIDER WORLD.

To be continued...